



# FileAtlas

Manual for the macOS app

Find, compare, organize, back up, and export files.

## For this version

This manual describes FileAtlas 1.9.0 Beta 2. The app works locally on your Mac and has no external dependencies.

macOS 26.5+ | Swift 6 | GPLv3

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## In short

FileAtlas does not modify files while scanning, filtering, comparing, or exporting. Only the cleanup queue can move items to the macOS Trash, and only after explicit confirmation.

# 1. Overview and navigation

FileAtlas is a local file analysis and management app. Add folders as scan locations; FileAtlas scans them recursively and presents results as a table or compact list.

## The main areas

| Area         | Purpose                                                                                        | Where                             |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Left sidebar | Locations, subfolders, quick access, filter sets, smart collections, and the duplicate filter. | Left side of the main window.     |
| Center       | File list or table with name, type, status, tags, size, and modified date.                     | Table/list switcher at top right. |
| Right        | Metadata and QuickLook preview for the selected file or folder.                                | Select an item in the center.     |
| Toolbar      | Search, scan, analysis, cleanup queue, settings, and export.                                   | Top of the window.                |

## Key controls

- Discord and GitHub buttons sit next to **FileAtlas** in the toolbar.
- The central search field searches the current index. Its scope control can include all indexed folders.
- The circular arrow scans the selected location again; while scanning, it becomes a cancel button.
- The gear opens Settings. The share icon opens Excel, PDF, and CSV export.

### Tip

The sidebar is intentionally transparent. It is for navigation; select items in the center list to work with them.

## 2. Getting started: locations and scans

**Where to find it:** Sidebar -> Locations -> Add Folder...

When you choose a folder, FileAtlas stores a Security-Scoped Bookmark. It lets FileAtlas reopen the folder after a restart without asking for it again.

### Run a scan

| Step | Action                                                                        |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Click <b>Add Folder...</b> in the Locations section and choose a folder.      |
| 2    | Select the location in the sidebar. It is scanned the first time you open it. |
| 3    | Wait for progress to finish; FileAtlas displays item count and indexed size.  |
| 4    | Use <b>Rescan</b> in the toolbar later to update the index.                   |

### Subfolders in the sidebar

Use the disclosure arrow to expand a folder. Children are loaded only when opened. Clicking a subfolder makes it the active view. Right-click a subfolder to add it to Quick Access or back it up directly.

### What scanning handles

- Folders are scanned recursively, and several locations can be managed at once.
- Bundles such as .app, .framework, and .xcodeproj are recognized as single items.
- Ignored folders are not scanned recursively, but appear as a single entry with their total size.
- Extension whitelist and ignored-folder rules apply on the next scan.

#### If results are missing

Settings -> Scan Settings -> Clear Cache removes only cached scan results, never files on disk. Scan the location again afterward.

## 3. Finding, filtering, and viewing files

### Search

**Where to find it:** Toolbar -> Search field

- Search by name, for example **Invoice** or **.dmg**.
- Search by extension, for example **dmg**, **pdf**, or **app**.
- Filter by size with **> 10 MB**, **< 500 KB**, or similar expressions.
- Enable all-folder search in the search field to include all indexed locations.

### Sort and change view

In table view, click a column heading to sort by Name, Type, Status, Tags, Size, or Modified date. Columns can be reordered. The segmented control in the toolbar switches between table and compact list view.

### Filters and filter sets

**Where to find it:** Settings -> Filter, or Sidebar -> Filter Sets

Filter by modified date, duplicates, and tags. Saved filter sets store include and exclude lists for recurring searches. The sidebar lets you activate, edit, or delete a filter set.

### Details and QuickLook

Select an item in the center list to show metadata on the right. App bundles also show bundle ID, version, and developer information. Press Space for QuickLook; supported files also show an inline preview.

### Tags

Right-click a file or folder to apply predefined or custom color-coded tags. Tags can later be used as a filter.

## 4. Tags, duplicates, snapshots, and folder comparison

### Find duplicates

**Where to find it:** Sidebar -> Duplicates -> Only duplicates

FileAtlas groups candidates by size and verifies matching candidates with SHA-256. Identical items show a gold badge. The Only duplicates switch limits the center list to verified duplicates.

#### Important

Matching names do not make files duplicates. The content hash is what verifies a duplicate.

### Snapshots and changes

**Where to find it:** Settings -> Snapshots

- Later scans can display a summary of new, changed, and removed items.
- You can save, compare, and delete snapshots in Settings.
- A snapshot stores index information only. Deleting one never deletes files on your Mac.
- FileAtlas keeps up to ten snapshots in its history.

### Compare two folders

**Where to find it:** Toolbar / comparison action -> Compare Folders

Choose Folder A and Folder B, then click Compare. Results show relative paths available in both folders, only in A, or only in B. Ignored-folder rules are applied here as well.

# 5. Storage analysis and cleanup queue

## Storage Analysis

**Where to find it:** Toolbar -> bar chart icon -> Storage Analysis

Storage Analysis summarizes item count, indexed size, and duplicates. It lists the largest indexed items and file-type totals. Click an item to reveal it in Finder.

## Cleanup Queue

**Where to find it:** File list -> right-click item -> Add to Cleanup Queue; then Toolbar -> trash icon

The queue is a review step. It does not move anything until you confirm the final action. You can remove individual entries or clear the entire queue.

| Action               | Effect                                                  |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Add to Cleanup Queue | Marks an item in FileAtlas only; no file is moved.      |
| Open queue           | Review every marked item with path and size.            |
| Move to Trash        | After confirmation, items are moved to the macOS Trash. |
| Empty Queue          | Removes FileAtlas queue entries only.                   |

### Safety principle

FileAtlas does not permanently delete items through this feature. They are moved to macOS Trash and can be restored according to macOS rules.

## 6. Rules and smart collections

### Rules

**Where to find it:** Settings -> Rules -> New Rule...

Rules are checked after a completed scan. They can evaluate file type, minimum size, and file age and report matching items. Rules never move, hide, or delete files.

- Give the rule a name.
- Optionally define extensions, a minimum size, and an age condition.
- Enable the rule and inspect its report after the next scan.
- Use **Run Rules Now** to evaluate it against the current index immediately.

### Smart Collections

**Where to find it:** Sidebar -> Smart Collections -> New Smart Collection..., or Settings -> Smart Collections

A smart collection is a saved dynamic view. It can filter by extension, minimum size, recently modified items, and duplicates. It changes no files and updates from the current index.

| Example          | Configuration                         |
|------------------|---------------------------------------|
| DMG archive      | Extension: dmg                        |
| Large downloads  | Minimum size, for example 1 GB        |
| Recent files     | Modified within the last 7 or 30 days |
| Duplicate review | Duplicates only enabled               |

## 7. Backups and restoration

FileAtlas deliberately separates configured backups for scan locations from quick backups of your current selection. A large scheduled full backup can therefore remain in place while small targeted archives are created quickly.

### A. Configure a scan-location backup

**Where to find it:** Sidebar -> right-click a top-level location -> Backup Settings..., or Settings -> Backup -> Settings

| Option            | Meaning                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Index only        | Writes a JSON file list. Fast and small, but without file contents.                                                                         |
| Full backup (ZIP) | Backs up the selected source recursively as a ZIP archive.                                                                                  |
| Both              | Creates both index JSON and full backup.                                                                                                    |
| Source            | For a full backup, choose a folder or one file as the source.                                                                               |
| Compress files    | Compresses suitable files. Large already-compressed files are streamed for speed.                                                           |
| SHA-256 manifest  | Writes a hash-manifest file next to the ZIP for later verification.                                                                         |
| AES-256 password  | Encrypts the ZIP. The password is stored in macOS Keychain. Use Keka, 7-Zip, or WinZip to open it; Finder does not support this encryption. |
| Schedule          | Off, daily, or weekly. Due scheduled backups run when FileAtlas launches, only while it is running.                                         |

### B. Back up files, multiple items, or a subfolder

**Where to find it:** Center file list -> select one or more items -> right-click -> Back Up Selected Items...

A selection backup creates one ZIP containing only the chosen sources. Multi-selection is supported. If a parent folder and one of its children are both selected, the child is not added twice.

**Where to find it:** Left sidebar -> right-click a subfolder -> Back Up This Folder...

The sheet lets you choose destination, compression, and an optional SHA-256 manifest. This quick backup does not change a configured full-backup source or schedule.

### Restore and test

- Find the generated **FileAtlas\_Backup\_...zip** in the chosen destination.
- Double-click the ZIP in Finder to extract it.
- Copy only the needed file or folder from the extracted contents to its desired location.
- For a test, back up a small selection, extract it, and open a file.
- With a SHA-256 manifest enabled, compare original and extracted files by their hash values if needed.

**Current behavior**

FileAtlas creates backups and shows their progress in the lower banner. Restoration currently uses normal extraction in Finder or a suitable ZIP utility.

## 8. Export, settings, and updates

### Export

**Where to find it:** Toolbar -> export icon, or Settings -> Export

Export the currently visible results as Excel (.xlsx), PDF, or CSV. Your active search, filters, and smart collection determine what is visible.

### Settings

**Where to find it:** Toolbar -> gear icon

| Section                   | What it contains                                                                    |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Appearance                | Light, Dark, System; row height; real or fast generic file icons.                   |
| Language                  | Deutsch, English, or System. German is preferred automatically for the DACH region. |
| Scan Settings             | Auto-scan on launch, rescan, and Clear Cache.                                       |
| Ignored Folders           | Names or folders to skip on the next scan.                                          |
| Filter Sets / Filter      | Saved filters, date, duplicate, and tag controls.                                   |
| Rules / Smart Collections | Automatic reports and dynamic views.                                                |
| Snapshots                 | Save, compare, and delete index snapshots.                                          |
| Backup / Export           | Configuration per scan location and the three export formats.                       |
| Info & Contact            | App version, update check, and a link to report issues.                             |

### Updates

Settings -> Info & Contact can run a check for updates. FileAtlas contacts GitHub Releases only; it does not upload indexed data, backups, passwords, or filters.

## 9. Practical workflows

### Find large files quickly

- 1. Scan the relevant location.
- 2. Open Storage Analysis and review the largest items.
- 3. Optionally search for **> 1 GB**.
- 4. Only after review, add items to the Cleanup Queue.

### Organize DMG files

- 1. Create a Smart Collection with extension **dmg**.
- 2. Sort the collection by size or date.
- 3. Tag important images or back them up as a selection.

### Back up before cleanup

- 1. Select affected files or a subfolder.
- 2. Right-click -> Back Up Selected Items... or Back Up This Folder...
- 3. Choose destination and optionally enable a hash manifest.
- 4. Test-extract the ZIP in Finder before cleanup.

### Track project changes

- 1. Add and scan the project folder.
- 2. Save a snapshot.
- 3. Rescan after changes and review the change summary or compare the snapshot.

# 10. Privacy, limitations, and help

## Local data and permissions

- Scan data, snapshots, filter sets, tags, and backup configuration are stored locally on your Mac.
- Security-Scoped Bookmarks keep the folder permissions you grant to FileAtlas.
- Passwords for encrypted backups are stored in macOS Keychain, never as plain text.
- The optional update check uses GitHub Releases only and sends no file or backup content.

## Important limitations

| Topic             | Note                                                                                             |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Encrypted ZIPs    | Finder cannot open AES-256 ZIP files. Use Keka, 7-Zip, or WinZip.                                |
| Scheduled backups | They are not a background service. They run at FileAtlas launch when due.                        |
| Restoration       | The app does not restore files itself yet. Extract the ZIP and copy files back.                  |
| Clear Cache       | Removes cached index data only. Files on your Mac remain unchanged.                              |
| Trash             | Cleanup moves items to Trash only after confirmation; permanent deletion follows macOS settings. |

## When something goes wrong

- If a folder is no longer accessible, add the location again or check its Finder permission.
- If results look stale, rescan the location; use Clear Cache first if necessary.
- If a ZIP has a problem, test a small selection without encryption and extract it in Finder.
- Report problems and suggestions through Settings -> Info & Contact -> GitHub.

### End of manual

FileAtlas is a local tool. For cleanup and backup operations, testing first with a small selection keeps each step clear and predictable.